

Firearms Trace Data: Montana - 2023

Data Source: Firearms Tracing System

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

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ATF Firearms Trace Data Disclaimer

Firearm traces are designed to assist law enforcement authorities in conducting investigations by tracking the sale and possession of specific firearms. Law enforcement agencies may request firearms traces for any investigative reason, and those reasons are not necessarily reported to the federal government. Not all firearms used in crime are traced and not all firearms traced are used in crime.

Firearms selected for tracing are not chosen for purposes of determining which types, makes or models of firearms are used for illicit purposes. The firearms selected do not constitute a random sample and should not be considered representative of the larger universe of all firearms used by criminals, or any subset of that universe. Firearms are normally traced to the first retail seller, and sources reported for firearms traced do not necessarily represent the sources or methods by which firearms in general are acquired for use in crime.

Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced in Montana in Calendar Year 2023

1,853

Firearm Types with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Pistols	893
Rifles	524
Shotguns	196
Revolvers	191
Machineguns	17
Derringers	12
Machinegun Conversion Devices	9
Receivers/Frames	5
Other*	6

* Other includes Silencers, Unknown Types, an Any Other Weapon and a Flare Gun.

Top Calibers Reported on Firearm Traces with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

9mm	466
.22 Cal	285
.45 Cal	142

12GA	141
.40 Cal	88
.380 Cal	62
.357 Cal	49
.30-06 Cal	42
7.62mm	42
5.56mm	41

NOTE: There were 440 additional traces that were associated with other calibers. There were 55 traces with an unknown caliber.

Top Categories Reported on Firearm Traces with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Found Firearm	450
Possession of Weapon	442
Firearm Under Investigation	222
Dangerous Drugs	193
Property Crimes	110
Weapon Offense	84
Aggravated Assault	51
Homicide	42
Suicide	37
Weapons Trafficking	28

NOTE: There were 194 additional traces that were associated with other categories.

Top 15 Source States for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Montana	1,013
Washington	44
Texas	29
Wyoming	27
Oregon	20
California	19
Colorado	18
Idaho	18
North Dakota	18
Florida	13
Arizona	12
Nevada	10
Minnesota	9
Georgia	7
Pennsylvania	7
Utah	7

NOTE: An additional 28 states and Puerto Rico accounted for 97 other traces. The source state was identified in 1,368 total traces.

Time-To-Crime Rates for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Under 3 Months	73
3 Months to Under 7 Months	58
7 Months to Under 1 Year	56
1 Year to Under 2 Years	138
2 Years to Under 3 Years	149
3 Years and Over	695

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 Montana Average Time-to-Crime: **8.86 Years**

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 National Average Time-to-Crime: **6.76 Years**

Age of Possessors for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

17 and Under	38
18 to 21	53
22 to 24	39
25 to 30	78
31 to 40	214
41 to 50	225
Over 50	233

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 Montana Average Age of Possessor: **41 Years**

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 National Average Age of Possessor: **35 Years**

Top Recovery Cities for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Billings	507
Kalispell	119
Great Falls	102
Helena	81
Missoula	80
Ennis	54
Havre	40
Malta	36
Thompson Falls	36
Colstrip	33

NOTE: There were 77 additional municipalities that accounted for 438 other traces. The recovery city could not be determined for 327 traces.

Analytical Criteria Used to Compile the Enclosed Statistics

Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced

- Includes traces with a recovery state of Montana. Traces in which the recovery state was not provided were included when the requesting agency state was equal to Montana.
- Includes Firearms Recovered and Traced between 1/1/2023 –12/31/2023 or, if the recovery date was blank, firearms with trace entry dates between 1/1/2023 –12/31/2023.

- Duplicate traces, Firearms Not Recovered, Gun Buyback and Firearms Turned In are not included in this figure.
- Data was extracted from the Firearms Tracing System (FTS) on April 10, 2024.
- All traces may not have been submitted or completed at the time of this study.

Firearm Types and Calibers with a Montana Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.

Top Categories Reported on Firearm Traces with a Montana Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.

Top Source States for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Traces must identify a purchaser and the state in which the final dealer is located.

Time-to-Crime Rates for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Traces must identify a purchaser.
- Time-to-Crime was calculated for those traces in which the purchase date could be subtracted from the recovery date.

Age of Possessors for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Includes traces that provide a possessor and the possessor's date of birth.
- Possessor's age is calculated by subtracting the possessor's date of birth from the recovery date.

Top Recovery Cities for Firearms with a Montana Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Includes traces with a recovery city or, if the recovery city was not provided, traces requested by agencies with jurisdiction only within that city.

[View All 2023 Firearms Trace Data](#)

Last updated: December 9, 2024